

Dionysius bar Šalibi: Commentary on the Apocalypse

English translation by Luke J. Stevens, 2020

Introduction

Dionysius bar Šalibi, Metropolitan of Amida in the twelfth century, was a prolific writer in Syriac, though only a fraction of his works have been critically edited and published, let alone translated.¹ His *Commentary on the Apocalypse* was published in 1909 in CSCO 53, followed by a Latin translation in CSCO 60.² Because of my ignorance of Syriac, I have translated from the Latin.³

Bar Šalibi's is the second-oldest extant commentary on Revelation in Syriac.⁴ Of the attention devoted to it, the lion's share revolves around its witness to Hippolytus of Rome,⁵ a prolific author of the early third century, and a certain Gaius whose objections Hippolytus answers in the *Commentary*, which frames the two as interlocutors. For these exchanges and probably for the bulk of the exegesis—both echoing Hippolytus's various writings⁶—the *Commentary* draws from, and is our

¹ See Sebastian P. Brock, "Dionysios bar Šalibi," in *Gorgias Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Syriac Heritage: Electronic Edition*, ed. Sebastian P. Brock, Aaron M. Butts, George A. Kiraz, and Lucas Van Rompay (Gorgias Press, 2011; online ed. Beth Mardutho, 2018), <https://gedsh.bethmardutho.org/Dionysios-bar-Salibi>.

² Jaroslav Sedláček, ed., *Dionysius Bar Šalibī: In Apocalypsim, Actus et Epistulas catholicas*, CSCO 53, 60 (Paris: Poussielgue, 1909–1910). Available online at <https://archive.org/details/inapocalypsimact00dion>.

³ Others have already translated a few excerpts into English directly from the Syriac, which I use where possible with minor adaptations: John Gwynn, "Hippolytus and His 'Heads against Caius,'" *Hermathena* 6 (1888): 397–418; John Gwynn, "Hippolytus on St. Matthew xxiv. 15–22," *Hermathena* 7 (1889): 137–50; Theodore H. Robinson, "The Authorship of the Muratorian Canon," *The Expositor* 7/1 (1906): 481–95. Transcripts of all these are collected by Roger Pearse at http://www.tertullian.org/fathers/dionysius_syrus_revelation_01.htm. Another translation of the *Commentary*'s introduction is provided in Sebastian P. Brock, *A Brief Outline of Syriac Literature*, Mōrān E'ṯhō' 9 (Kottayam, Kerala: St. Ephrem Ecumenical Research Institute, 2011), 267–68 ([link](#)).

⁴ For the oldest, see Stan Larson, "The Earliest Syriac Commentary on the Apocalypse: Transcription, Translation and Importance of Brit. Lib. Ms. Add. 17,127" (PhD diss., University of Birmingham, 1984) ([link](#)). Bar Šalibi shows no knowledge of it.

⁵ To discuss Hippolytus at all immediately evokes the notorious Hippolytus Question—for an overview of which see Ronald E. Heine, "Hippolytus, Ps.-Hippolytus and the Early Canons," in *The Cambridge History of Early Christian Literature*, ed. Frances Young, Lewis Ayres, and Andrew Louth (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 142–51 ([link](#))—but here a single Hippolytus will be presumed.

⁶ See Pierre Prigent, "Hippolyte, commentateur de l'Apocalypse," *TZ* 28 (1972): 391–412 ([link](#)); Pierre Prigent and Ralph Stehly, "Les fragments du *De Apocalypsi* d'Hippolyte," *TZ* 29 (1973): 313–33 ([link](#)); Allen Brent, *Hippolytus and the Roman Church in the Third Century: Communities in Tension before the Emergence of a Monarch-Bishop*, VCSup 31 (Leiden: Brill, 1995), 150–61 ([link](#)). Furthermore, a number of parallels with Victorinus of Poetovio (writing in Latin in the mid-to-late third century) are attributable to various Hippolytan writings, some not extant; see Martine Dulaey, *Victorin de Poetovio, premier exégète latin*, Collection des Études augustiniennes, Série Antiquité 139–140 (Paris: Études augustiniennes, 1993), 288–93.

principal witness to, the lost pseudo-Hippolytan *Chapters against Gaius* (probably of the mid-third century).⁷ The *Commentary* also incorporates several passages from Hippolytus's *On Christ and Antichrist*⁸ and an epistle of Severus of Antioch, besides drawing heavily in its introduction from Eusebius's *Ecclesiastical History* (likely at second hand). Bar Šalibi's original contributions apparently include at least explanations of terms (e.g., *robe*, *Abaddon*). The commentary mostly proceeds in order through Revelation's text, although the sources followed sometimes draw in nearby verses.

This annotated translation, unpolished as it is, aims to make the *Commentary* more accessible to a wide audience, including not only those studying Hippolytus and Pseudo-Hippolytus, but also those who may wish to investigate other topics.

Translation

WE INVOKE GOD UNTO OUR AID, THAT WE WRITE PARTS
FROM THE INTERPRETATION OF THE REVELATION OF JOHN; WE HAVE
FOUND VERY LITTLE OF THE LABOR OF OUR PREDECESSORS, BUT WE
HAVE ELUCIDATED THE MOST FROM THE GIFT GIVEN TO US BY THE
LORD. WE BEGIN IN THE HELP OF OUR LORD AND OUR GOD.⁹

Now that we have finished the exposition of the Gospel,¹⁰ brethren, fully and very clearly, we come and approach the exposition of the Revelation of John the Evangelist. But do you, readers, with the students of the spiritual inquiries maintain your prayers for Dionysius the stranger, according as you also will be saved.

At the beginning of the treatise we must say that there are many teachers who are in doubt regarding the Revelation of John and say that it is not his. And Eusebius of Caesarea declares the same thing in his ecclesiastical writings (i.e., in the *History of the Church*).¹¹ For Dionysius, bishop of Alexandria, says that the Revelation was not that of John the Apostle, but of another John, the Presbyter, who lived in Asia.¹² The reason is, that the style of the Revelation is not like the type of the language of the Gospel. Also, John makes no mention of his name at all in the Gospel but does put his name at the beginning and end of the Revelation. Now, we agree that he received the Revelation of which he wrote from our Lord. Irenaeus the bishop and Hippolytus of Bostra say that the Revelation is that of John the

⁷ Sixth-century fragments of it were brought to light in Sebastian P. Brock, ed., *Catalogue of Syriac Fragments (New Finds) in the Library of the Monastery of Saint Catherine, Mount Sinai* (Athens: Mount Sinai Foundation, 1995), 17–19, 92–96, 137, 196–98; with indispensable analysis in Alberto Camplani and Emanuela Prinzivalli, “Sul significato dei nuovi frammenti siriaci dei *Capitula adversus Caium* attribuiti a Ippolito,” *Aug* 38 (1998): 49–82. These are referenced below as the Brock fragments.

⁸ Andrew S. Jacobs, <http://andrewjacobs.org/translations/hippolytus.html>, provides a modern translation. Since the work circulated in Syriac, would be of obvious value to a commentator on Revelation, and is quoted at length nearly verbatim, it is likely that Bar Šalibi has used it at first hand.

⁹ From here to Rev 1:4, the translation is adapted from Robinson, “Authorship,” 486–88.

¹⁰ His *Commentary on the Gospels*.

¹¹ Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 3.25.4.

¹² Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 7.25, quoting Dionysius of Alexandria's *On the Promises*—although the suggestion of John the Presbyter is Eusebius's in 3.39.6.

Evangelist, and that it was granted about the end of the reign of Domitian.¹³ And Eusebius of Caesarea agrees with this, but immediately says that some do not accept it as being the Revelation of John the Apostle, so saying that it is the work of John the Elder, who was a contemporary of John the Apostle; and there are two tombs in Asia, one being that of the Evangelist, the other that of John the Elder.¹⁴

Hippolytus of Rome said: a man named Gaius appeared, who said that neither the Gospel nor yet the Revelation was John's, but that they were the work of Cerinthus the heretic.¹⁵ And the blessed Hippolytus opposed this Gaius and showed that the teaching of John in the Gospel and Revelation was different from that of Cerinthus.¹⁶ This Cerinthus was one who taught circumcision and was angry with Paul when he did not circumcise Titus, and the Apostle calls him and his disciples in one of his letters *sham apostles and crafty workers*.¹⁷ Again, he teaches that the world was created by angels, and that our Lord was not born of a virgin.¹⁸ He also teaches carnal eating and drinking,¹⁹ and many other blasphemies. The Gospel and Revelation of John, however, are like the teaching that the Scriptures contain; and so they are liars who say that the Revelation is not by the Apostle John.

And we agree with Hippolytus. That the Revelation is the Evangelist John's is attested also by St. Cyril and Mar Severus and all the teachers who bring evidence

¹³ On Irenaeus, cf. Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 3.18, 3.23.1–4, 5.8.5–7. Irenaeus indeed affirms authorship by the same John (e.g., *Haer.* 4.20.11), but Eusebius misrepresents Irenaeus's statement about Domitian: although the syntax is ambiguous, Irenaeus means that *John*, rather than *his vision*, was seen even near the end of Domitian's reign (as the same peculiar error appears earlier in Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 10.3, 13.2, it most likely goes back to Origen). Although Eusebius nowhere indicates so, Hippolytus of Rome indeed affirms the same authorship (e.g., *Antichr.* 36.1), without, so far as we know, ever saying anything of the circumstances of John's exile. The erroneous toponym "of Bostra" stems from a misreading of Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 6.20.2, where Beryllus of Bostra is mentioned alongside Hippolytus; see John A. Cerrato, *Hippolytus between East and West: The Commentaries and the Provenance of the Corpus*, Oxford Theological Monographs (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002), 72–75 ([link](#)). The toponym is earlier attested in Syriac (e.g., in the ninth-century British Library Add. 17194, fol. 52a, according to the [catalogue](#)), and its occurrence in the Armenian and Georgian traditions is probably also traceable to the Syriac (though the same misreading seems to have occurred independently in Latin). Since Bar Ṣalibi elsewhere always refers to Hippolytus *of Rome*, this anomaly betrays his use here of an intermediary, which need not be later than the sixth century.

¹⁴ Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 3.39.6.

¹⁵ Cf. Epiphanius, *Haer.* 51.3.3–6, where this is the position of the "Alogi"; Dionysius of Alexandria, *On the Promises*, apud Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 7.25.2, also mentions the allegation that Revelation was written by Cerinthus. Bar Ṣalibi hands down the responses of Hippolytus (the fictional interlocutor) in the *Chapters against Gaius* to objections on both Revelation and John's Gospel: while those on Revelation are incorporated throughout the present commentary, one objection on John is addressed in the *Commentary on the Gospels* at John 2:1. There, although the manuscripts disagree on whether the heretic is specified as Gaius (see J. Rendel Harris, "Presbyter Gaius and the Fourth Gospel," in *Hermas in Arcadia: And Other Essays* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1896], 43–59, at 47–50; Pierre de Labriolle, *La crise montaniste*, Bibliothèque de la Fondation Thiers 31 [Paris: Leroux, 1913], 285), the response is ascribed to Hippolytus, and the exchange corresponds in substance to Epiphanius, *Haer.* 51.4–31. The "Hippolytus" and "Gaius" of the *Chapters against Gaius* presumably are very loosely based upon the historical Hippolytus and the "Gaius" character in the *Dialogue with Proclus*, though it is unlikely that either dialogue was actually written by its protagonist, as readers assumed.

¹⁶ Cf. Epiphanius, *Haer.* 51.4.1–2.

¹⁷ 2 Cor 11:13; cf. Epiphanius, *Haer.* 28.4.

¹⁸ Cf. Epiphanius, *Haer.* 28.1.2; Irenaeus, *Haer.* 1.26.1; Hippolytus, *Haer.* 10.17.

¹⁹ Cf. Dionysius of Alexandria, *On the Promises*, apud Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 7.25.3.

from it. Also the Theologian, in his *Farewell Address*, testifies that there is no proof from the conclusion, and says, “as John taught me by his Revelation, he made a way for thy people, and these stones...”—where he calls the heretics and their teaching stones.²⁰

The Revelation of Jesus Christ, etc.—Hence he begins with that which was revealed to him in a vision concerning those things which were about to be. Rev 1:1

To his servant John—He records his name in the Revelation that we may believe what he saw. In the Gospel he does not record his name, because there was no need for it there, since all the Apostles were witnesses of what our Lord did.

John to the seven churches, which are in Asia—By *churches*, he indicates cities and calls them *churches* because of the excellence of the elect who were in them.²¹ He says seven, because the number seven was in high esteem among the Hebrews in the Scriptures. And there are seven gifts of one Spirit²² descending on one Church.²³ Rev 1:4

Hippolytus says: In writing to seven Churches, he writes just as Paul wrote thirteen letters but wrote them to seven Churches.²⁴ That to the Hebrews he does not judge to be Paul’s, but perhaps Clement’s.²⁵

From him who is and who was—This indicates that (the book) is John the Apostle’s; for thus he writes in the Gospel: *In the beginning was the Word*, etc.²⁶ By the words *who is*, he indicates God.²⁷

And from the seven spirits—He indicates the operations of the Spirit.

²⁰ Gregory of Nazianzus, *Or.* 42.9. Cf. Andrew of Caesarea, *Comm. Apoc.* [prol.](#), likewise citing on this very question Gregory, Cyril of Alexandria, Irenaeus, and Hippolytus, as well as Papias and Methodius; and Oecumenius, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.5, citing Athanasius, Basil, Gregory, Methodius, Cyril, and Hippolytus.

²¹ Cf. Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.8.

²² [Isa 11:2–3](#).

²³ Cf. Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.6–7.

²⁴ The notion of the Pauline corpus being addressed, like John’s Apocalypse, to seven churches is otherwise witnessed only in the Latin tradition; see Nils Alstrup Dahl, “The Particularity of the Pauline Epistles as a Problem in the Ancient Church,” in *Neotestamentica et Patristica: Eine Freundesgabe Herrn Oscar Cullmann zu seinem 60. Geburtstag überreicht*, ed. W. C. van Unnik, NTSup 6 (Leiden: Brill, 1962), 261–71. In particular, cf. Cyprian, *Test.* 1.20 and *Fort.* 11; Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 1.7 and *Fabr.* 8; and the Muratorian Fragment. Robinson, “Authorship,” 481–95, in fact argues, largely from this point in Bar Šalibi, that the Muratorian Fragment was written by Hippolytus; more recent work, however, identifies it as excerpted from a lost work of Victorinus (Jonathan J. Armstrong, “Victorinus of Pettau as the Author of the Canon Muratori,” *VC* 62 [2008]: 1–34). Here Victorinus is not dependent upon Cyprian, nor is their common exegetical source likely to be Hippolytus, but rather Melito (Luke J. Stevens, “Twenty-Four Elders: Revelation and the Old Testament Canon in Victorinus and Melito,” *J ECS*, forthcoming).

²⁵ Robinson’s translation ends here. Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 6.20.3, records that Gaius of Rome (!) counted thirteen Pauline Epistles and excluded Hebrews; here and in *Hist. eccl.* 3.3.5, Eusebius adds that the Pauline authorship of Hebrews remains disputed in Rome. Hippolytus’s lost *Syntagma* in fact rejected Pauline authorship, as reported in Photius, *Bibl. cod.* 121 (see also Stephen Gobar apud Photius, *Bibl. cod.* 232). Origen, a staunch defender of Pauline authorship of Hebrews, observes in his *Hom. Heb.* (apud Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 6.25.11–14), that its scribe was identified by some before him as Luke (as indeed Clement of Alexandria did, making Luke Paul’s translator) and by others (Hippolytus?) as Clement of Rome. Eusebius himself, in *Hist. eccl.* 3.38.2–3, surmises that Hebrews was translated by Clement.

²⁶ [John 1:1](#).

²⁷ Cf. [Ex 3:14](#).

And from Jesus Christ—the son incarnate. Firstborn of the dead—who first rose in the flesh in incorruptibility. [Rev 1:5](#)

*I am the Aleph and the Taw*²⁸—the beginning and the end. [Rev 1:8](#)

Who is and who was and who is to come—He expounds three times. He is God today and yesterday and forever, according to the word of the apostle.²⁹ *Is* signifies present time, and *was*, past time, and *is to come*, future time, as God is above times and spaces and moments.

I was on the isle of Patmos—All the books attest that the apostle was expelled³⁰ to the isle of Patmos, and also the epistle that Dionysius the Areopagite wrote to him there.³¹ *Because of the word of God*—because of the faith. [Rev 1:9](#)

I was in the Spirit, on the day of the Lord—He calls the first day of the week the Lord's, because on that day our Lord rose from the tomb, and on that day the Spirit descended upon the apostles, and on that day creation was created, and on that day our Lord arose. [Rev 1:10](#)

Seven churches, to Ephesus, to Smyrna, etc.—Those cities are in the region of Asia; the beginning calls them churches. [Rev 1:11](#)

I saw seven golden lampstands—he calls lampstands the churches of those cities. Just as a lampstand gives light to the inhabitants of a house, so the churches illuminate with their teaching the peoples who lie in sin. [Rev 1:12](#)

Clothed in a robe—Covering the feet and complete, or a garment that descends all the way to the feet. The Syrian [version] calls the robe an ephod. [Rev 1:13](#)

Son of Man—God the Word is called by this name when he became flesh in accordance with what he was made. He is now called Son of Man, although he is God, because he became man without change. Again, he is called Son of Man, because he was the son of that new man who existed before the transgression of the commandment. For the body and soul that Adam had before the transgression of the commandment, the Word assumed when he became flesh.³²

And girding his breasts, a golden belt—He calls the two testaments breasts.³³ He calls the peoples a belt, or girdle; just as a belt girds the loins with clothes, so also Christ has bound with his love those who believe his truth.³⁴

His eyes like flame—He calls eyes the operations of the Holy Spirit. [Rev 1:14](#)

Like Lebanese bronze—however: the mystery of the fathers is figured in the feet, which are solid in works just like bronze. [Rev 1:15](#)

And his voice like the voice of many waters—By voice he designates his teaching like water, according to that: *rivers of living water flow from his belly*.³⁵

²⁸ First and last letters of the Syriac alphabet, thus analogous to *alpha* and *omega* in the Greek.

²⁹ [Heb 13:8](#).

³⁰ Cf. Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 3.18.1; Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 36.1.

³¹ Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, *Ep.* 10.

³² This paragraph's translation follows W. E. F. W. Carr, ed., *Gregory Abu'l Faraj, Commonly Called Bar-Hebraeus: Commentary on the Gospels from the Horreum Mysteriorum* (London: SPCK, 1925), lxxxix–xc ([link](#)).

³³ Cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Cant.* 2.3, 3.3; *Ben. Is. Jac.* 26.

³⁴ Cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Dan.* 4.37.2.

³⁵ [John 7:38](#).

In his right hand seven stars—seven ministering spirits, which are in his power, as in his hand: the lampstands of the churches. [Rev 1:16](#)

And out of his mouth a sharp sword—the divine word, which is sharper than a sword against the evil.

And his face like the sun—to the good he will appear glorious and mild in countenance.

To the angel of the church in Ephesus, write—Make note to the minister of the Ephesians and to his congregation, although they are patient and refute the evil, yet shortly is their love toward God to run out. [Rev 2:1](#)

Whence have you fallen?—Pay attention to what kind of honor you were in the beginning. [Rev 2:5](#)

I will remove your lampstand—If the people is not converted, or the church that is the lampstand, from evil, it will be cast away from the face of the Son. Such is one justice to you.

Because you hate the works of the Nicolaitans—The heresies are those called according to the name of Nicholas. For he was one of the seven deacons who were constituted with Stephen;³⁶ when he was made a disciple, he dismissed his wife, who was beautiful; and he lived chastely, and she also likewise. When a certain time had passed, there arose certain ones after him, and they made their wives common.³⁷ [Rev 2:6](#)

Tree of life—Christ, or his precious body.³⁸ [Rev 2:7](#)

And to the angel of the church of Smyrna—Those cities are in the region of Asia. [Rev 2:8](#)

I am the first—eternal and from the beginning. *And the last*—without end. [...] and in the end of times I have put on the body.

And I will give him that hidden manna—the body. [Rev 2:17](#)

White stone—It means baptism.³⁹ *And on the stone a new name*—of Christians.⁴⁰ [...]

I urge you to buy from me proven gold—He calls *gold* the divine nature; he urges that we give what we possess to the poor. And for the alms he will give you the precious glory of his divinity: in this world, indeed, wisdom and knowledge, and in the future the splendor of the angels. [Rev 3:18](#)

And white garments for being clothed—He names *white garments* good works: faith, fasting, and prayer, with the rest of the virtues. And he calls *eye salve* the light of divine knowledge and understanding, which is obtained by reading the Scriptures, which illuminate the covered eyes. He names *eyes* the sense, the faculties of the soul: mind, intellect, understanding, knowledge, discretion; by

³⁶ [Acts 6:5](#).

³⁷ Cf. Clement of Alexandria, *Strom.* 3.25.5–26.2 (widely known through Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 3.29). On the other hand, the account of the Nicolaitans is rather different in Hippolytus, *Haer.* 7.24; Pseudo-Tertullian, *Haer.* 1.6; Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 2.1; Epiphanius, *Haer.* 25.

³⁸ Cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Cant.* 25.7.

³⁹ Cf. Hippolytus (?), *Trad. ap.* 21.

⁴⁰ Cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Dan.* 4.9.2; Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 2.3.

which the soul sees the spiritual world; and he teaches that by these eyes we should take away the darkness of evil.

Stone of jasper—jasper or onyx, i.e., like white lead is his likeness. And of carnelian—He is of red color like fire. Of emerald—The color of emerald is like beet. Sea of glass like crystal—of ice.

Twenty-four elders—They are of the order of Thrones.

And four living creatures—order of Cherubim.⁴¹ And those having six wings are Seraphim;⁴² but in the Apocalypse he says the Cherubim have six wings and they exclaim: “Holy!” For by the church above the Son of Thunder⁴³ is illuminated with this revelation.

Four living creatures full of eyes—Each living creature has four faces;⁴⁴ because when one is the Gospel, it seems quadriform.

The first living creature like a lion—By this he shows the kingdom and sovereignty of the lion who has arisen from the tribe of Judah; Matthew shows this. The second living creature like a calf—The bull signifies the priestly⁴⁵ glory of Christ, of which Luke tells. The third living creature has the face of a man—He shows the passibility of the Son and the lowly condition of the Son of Man who was among men, of which Mark tells. And the fourth living creature a figure of a flying eagle—By the eagle he indicates the tremendous spiritual mystery of the Word and teaches that his power extends into the heavens; John proclaims this.⁴⁶

A book written within and without, sealed with seven seals—For truly, too, unknown to the Jews were the secrets of the prophets; now Christ has opened all

⁴¹ Ezek 10.

⁴² Isa 6:2.

⁴³ Mark 3:17.

⁴⁴ Ezek 1:6.

⁴⁵ The critical edition has *ṣūṣ* (sweet; *eximia* in the Latin translation), which must have arisen at some point from misreading *ṣūṣ* (priestly), as in the parallels (see next note).

⁴⁶ Hippolytus, *Comm. Cant.* 8.6, provides this whole interpretation of the four living creatures in terms of the four gospels. However, Bar Ṣalibi's other commentaries—his *Commentary on the Gospels* 33 ([link](#); [translation](#)) and his *Literal Commentary on Ezekiel* ([link](#))—interpret Ezekiel's living creatures as the four evangelists, but differently, without linking a specific animal to each evangelist. The present passage has a close parallel in Syriac in the *Catena Severi*—printed in Jean-Baptiste Pitra, *Analecta sacra spicilegio solesmensi parata* (Paris: Publico Galliarum Typographeo, 1883), 4:41 ([link](#); Latin trans. p. 311) (likewise in Lagarde's earlier edition)—which Hans Achelis, *Hippolytus Werke*, GCS 1 (Leipzig: Hinrichs, 1897), 2:183 ([link](#)), translates into German, in turn translated into English in Kenneth Stevenson and Michael Glerup, eds., *Ezekiel, Daniel*, ACCS 13 (Downers Grove IL: InterVarsity, 2008), 5–6 ([link](#)). Since Hippolytus is cited in the catena's section on Ezekiel (see the [catalogue](#)), Pitra has inserted the misleading heading (in Latin) “St. Hippolytus, from his commentary on Ezekiel”—presumably recalling the *On Portions of Ezekiel* listed among Hippolytus's works in Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 6.22.2—which has then induced Achelis to place this passage (along with subsequent passages in the catena, as “inauthentic fragments”!) under the latter title; in fact, the catena simply ascribes to Hippolytus this single passage, clearly recognizable—despite some rearrangement in a botched attempt to conform to Ezekiel's order of the four animals—from his *Commentary on the Song of Songs* (cf. Dulaey, *Victorin*, 2:73n90). However, the catena passage begins by saying that “Ezekiel also showed,” which is neither from Hippolytus nor proper to the catena, and therefore due to an intermediary, presumably the *Chapters against Gaius*: here in Bar Ṣalibi, we can imagine the response to Gaius's contrast between Ezekiel's vision and Revelation's (e.g., the different number of wings), followed by adducing Hippolytus's authentic interpretation of Ezekiel's vision as prophetic ratification of John's Gospel.

things to the believing. For he himself is the perfect seal and *the key of David, who opens and no one shuts*,⁴⁷ just as John says below: *Worthy are you to take the book and open its seals*⁴⁸—He therefore takes the book and opens it, for what has been said about himself secretly before is now proclaimed openly upon the rooftops.⁴⁹ Again, the *book* of which John speaks represents the soul, and the *seven seals* upon it are the seven gifts of the Spirit. Again, in a man's head are seven doors: two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and a mouth.⁵⁰

Bowls, or jugs, represent patens. [Rev 5:8](#)

The lamb opened one of the seven seals—He wants to give this notice about future time. [Rev 6:1](#)

By the *white horse*, etc., he shows the faith, which is spread out into the four plagues, and all nations have confessed Christ and been saved,⁵¹ according to which Luke says: Believe, so *that times of quiet may come to you*.⁵² [Rev 6:2](#)

By the *red horse*, battle and the shedding of the blood of the saints, which the pagans have poured out. [Rev 6:4](#)

By the *black horse*, he indicates the time of suffering that falls upon the earth because of the iniquities and impieties that are multiplied. [Rev 6:5](#)

A quart of wheat for a denarius—This announces the famine, which there will be because of the impious in the end; he calls a cabus a quart measure, which is a third of a modius [...] in the region of Phrygia and Galatia. [Rev 6:6](#)

Green horse indicates death and ruin, which will come in the end of times upon the inhabitants of the earth because of their evil works. [Rev 6:8](#)

I saw under the altar the souls that have been killed—of the prophets, the apostles, and the saints. [Rev 6:9](#)

Until when, Lord, do you not judge—This shows that he serves the life of the soul and its memory. [Rev 6:10](#)

And a white garment was given to each of them—the clothing of incorruptibility, with which they are to clothe themselves. [Rev 6:11](#)

Until their companions are also complete—until the fullness of the elect enters. For Paul said: *So that they will not be perfected without us*.⁵³

The sixth seal signifies the end, when the Lord will have already risen from the heavens, after the killing that the Antichrist will do. [Rev 6:12](#)

By *four angels*, who appeared afterward, he indicates: by the four plagues they are to gather the sons of Adam and are ready to destroy the earth and its foundations. [Rev 7:1](#)

An angel who has the seal of God—holding in hand the sign of the cross. He calls *signed* those who have confessed the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit and with faith have proffered works of virtues. [Rev 7:2](#)

⁴⁷ [Rev 3:7](#).

⁴⁸ [Rev 5:9](#).

⁴⁹ Cf. [Matt 10:27](#). For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Dan.* 4.33.6–34.3.

⁵⁰ Cf. [Canon 7](#) of the Council of Constantinople; Clement of Alexandria, *Strom.* 6.144.2 (= Philo, *Leg.* 1.12).

⁵¹ Cf. Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 6.1.

⁵² [Acts 3:20](#).

⁵³ [Heb 11:40](#).

And when he had opened the seventh seal, etc.—because this too is written, [Rev 8:1](#)
it is to happen in the end of time.

And the first blared and there was made hail and fire, mixed with blood, and [Rev 8:7](#)
they were cast upon the earth, and a third of the earth was burnt—[...]

And the second angel opened and as much as a great mountain was cast in the [Rev 8:8](#)
*sea, and a third of the sea was also made blood, etc.—*The heretic Caius impugned
this vision and said: It is impossible that those things should be, for *like a thief who*
*comes in the night,*⁵⁴ so will be the coming of the Lord.

Hippolytus of Rome refuted him and said:⁵⁵ In like manner as God wrought
signs such as these in Egypt, so is he to work when Christ appears. And those that
were wrought in Egypt were partial, inasmuch as a part of the people was subjected
there; but these are to be general,⁵⁶ before the judgment, on all the world.
Accordingly, by the revelation John declared that there are to be plagues before
the judgment, as though for the avenging of the righteous and retribution on the
unbelieving, that when involved in these they may not trouble the faithful. So also
the Lord said, *There shall be in that day tribulation such as has been none like it;*⁵⁷ and
Joel, *I will show signs in heaven and on earth, blood and fire and vapor of smoke. The*
sun shall be turned into darkness and the moon into blood, before the day of the Lord
*come;*⁵⁸ and Amos, *To what end is the day of the Lord for you, when it is dark and not*
light? In like manner, *as if you fled from a lion and a bear met you, or one leaned his*
*hands on a wall and a serpent bit him.*⁵⁹ The text, that *the day of the Lord comes as a*
*thief,*⁶⁰ signifies as regards the unbelieving that they are darkness, inasmuch as the
faithful *are children of light, who walk not in the night.*⁶¹ Accordingly, in Egypt this
type was completed; for the Egyptians had darkness, but the Hebrews had light.⁶²

And the name of the star is called wormwood; and a third of the water was [Rev 8:11](#)
*made into wormwood, and many men died—*Wormwood is a bitter root, and
everything into which it is put turns into bitterness. And before the Lord's coming,
thus will befall the pagans who do evil to the Christians: for the waters, their drink,
are converted into bitterness. It is a figure of the fountain of Marah, at which the
Hebrews encamped; the Lord made the water sweet with wood, for those who
believed.⁶³ And just as for the Egyptians the waters were made blood and for the
Hebrews the waters were pure, so before that day will the unfaithful be struck with
the bitterness of the water.

⁵⁴ [1 Thess 5:2](#).

⁵⁵ From here, throughout Rev 8:8, the translation is adapted from Gwynn, "Hippolytus and His 'Heads against Caius,'" 399–400.

⁵⁶ Gwynn, "Hippolytus and His 'Heads against Caius,'" 418, notes the parallel of partial and complete fulfilment in Hippolytus, *Antichr.* [15.1](#).

⁵⁷ [Matt 24:21](#).

⁵⁸ [Joel 2:30–31](#).

⁵⁹ [Amos 5:18–19](#).

⁶⁰ [2 Pet 3:10](#).

⁶¹ [John 11:10, 12:35–36; Eph 5:8](#).

⁶² [Ex 10:22–23](#).

⁶³ [Ex 15:22–26](#). As explained there, *Marah* means *bitter*.

*And the fourth angel opened, and a third of the sun was struck, and a third of the moon and a third of the stars, that a third of them would be dark*⁶⁴—Gaius said: Just as in the Flood the heavenly bodies were not taken away and suddenly submerged, thus also is it to be in the end, as it is written;⁶⁵ and Paul says, *When they shall say, peace and safety, destruction shall come upon them.*⁶⁶

But Hippolytus said, in reply to this objection of the heretic: Before the Flood there was none of these signs, inasmuch as the Flood was partial; and the heavenly bodies were not removed, inasmuch as the general end had not arrived;⁶⁷ but when *heaven and earth are about to pass away*,⁶⁸ it must needs be that by little and little their splendor shall perish. And to this Joel testifies: *Before him verily the earth shall be confounded and the heavens shaken, and the sun and moon shall be darkened, and the stars their light shall set.*⁶⁹ And our Lord said, in the book of Luke, *And there shall be signs in the sun and moon and stars, and on the earth distress of nations, and the powers which are in heaven shall be shaken.*⁷⁰ And as to this, that he sent a manifest token, it is with regard to the non-perception of the unbelieving that he signifies. And as to the text, *When they shall say peace, destruction shall come upon them*, it is with regard to the Jews that he signifies, that they expect to possess their land and to be able to live in peace, and forthwith Christ appears and they are put to shame.

*And he opened the pit of the abyss, and smoke arose like the smoke of a furnace, and the sun was darkened, and the air. And from the smoke went out locusts onto the earth, and power was given to them like the scorpions of the earth, etc.*⁷¹—Gaius objects to this: According to this, the unrighteous are consumed by the locusts; whereas Scripture has said that sinners prosper and the righteous are persecuted, in the world;⁷² and Paul, that the faithful *shall be persecuted and the evil shall flourish, deceiving and being deceived.*⁷³

But Hippolytus answers him and says: The faithful, those who are persecuted by the unrighteous, at this period are to have rest, because they have been sealed; but the unrighteous who persecuted the saints, on them comes the plague of locusts; even as the Egyptians were devoured, and the Hebrews were free from the plagues, while they dwelt in one place.⁷⁴ Thus the saints in this time are to be in well-being, even as our Lord said, *When these things begin to be, be of good cheer, and lift up your heads, inasmuch as your redemption is nigh;*⁷⁵ that is,

⁶⁴ From here, throughout Rev 8:12, the translation is adapted from Gwynn, “Hippolytus and His ‘Heads against Caius,’” 400–401.

⁶⁵ Cf. [Matt 24:37](#).

⁶⁶ [1 Thess 5:3](#).

⁶⁷ Again, as in note 56 above.

⁶⁸ [Matt 24:35](#).

⁶⁹ [Joel 2:10](#).

⁷⁰ [Luke 21:25–26](#).

⁷¹ The translation of this exchange is adapted from Gwynn, “Hippolytus and His ‘Heads against Caius,’” 401.

⁷² Cf. [Ps 72\(73\):12–14](#); [Eccl 8:14](#).

⁷³ [2 Tim 3:12–13](#).

⁷⁴ Cf. [Ex 7–12](#).

⁷⁵ [Luke 21:28](#).

when plagues come on the evil, the righteous have rest. And this, that *evil men deceive and are deceived*, at the present day is coming to pass: that crafty men, who alter the words of the Lord and of the Scriptures after their evil thoughts, that even though at the present day they are proceeding further, yet in the end they are to be rebuked: *even as Jannes and Jambres, who withstood Moses*,⁷⁶ and afterwards were overcome and put to shame.

*And the angel of the abyss, whose name in Hebrew is Abaddon, and his name in Greek, Apollyon—however: “releasing” or “destroying” or “letting loose”.*⁷⁷ [Rev 9:11](#)

*And the four angels were released who had been bound and prepared for the time and the day that they would kill a third of men, etc.*⁷⁸—Gaius: It is not written that angels are to make war, nor that a third part of men is to perish, but: *Nation shall rise against nation.*⁷⁹ [Rev 9:14–15](#)

Against him, Hippolytus: It is not of angels he says that they are to go to war, but that four nations are to arise out of the region that is by the Euphrates, and to come against the earth, and to war with mankind. But this that he says, *four angels*, is not alien from Scripture. Moses said, *When he dispersed the sons of Adam, he set the boundary of the nations according to the number of the angels of God.*⁸⁰ Since therefore nations have been assigned to angels, and each nation pertains to one angel, John rightly declared by the Revelation: *Release those four angels*, who are the Persians, and the Medes, and the Babylonians, and the Assyrians.⁸¹ Since then these angels who have been appointed over the nations have not been commanded to stir up those who have been assigned to them, a certain bond of the power of the word is indicated, which restrains them until the day shall arrive and the Lord of all shall command.⁸² And this then is to happen when the Antichrist shall come.

Two hundred million—This is also written in Ezekiel of that large number: All his host *he will gather from the sun’s rising to the sun’s setting.*⁸³ Both those whom he called and those whom he did not call will go with him. [Rev 9:16](#)

Their breastplates like fire and hyacinth and sulfur—By this he shows the clothes of those who will come from the places of the nations, because the peoples are dressed in a variety of colors who live at the banks of the Euphrates.⁸⁴ [Rev 9:17](#)

And the heads of their horses like heads of lions, and out of their mouth comes fire—This is also said by Isaiah: *they run like lions and like lion’s whelps.*⁸⁵ For he says

⁷⁶ [2 Tim 3:8–9](#).

⁷⁷ See Larson, “Earliest Syriac Commentary,” 416–17.

⁷⁸ The translation of this exchange is adapted from Gwynn, “Hippolytus and His ‘Heads against Caius,’” 402.

⁷⁹ [Matt 24:7](#).

⁸⁰ [Deut 32:8](#) (LXX).

⁸¹ Cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Dan.* 3.9.10; Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* 6.6; Epiphanius, *Haer.* 51.34.2–7.

⁸² On Hippolytus’s response here, cf. Epiphanius, *Haer.* 51.34.1–7.

⁸³ [Ps 106\(107\):3](#); cf. [Ezek 36:24](#).

⁸⁴ Cf. Epiphanius, *Haer.* 51.34.8.

⁸⁵ Cf. [Isa 5:29](#).

this showing the vehemence and bitterness of those who will be gathered with the Antichrist.⁸⁶

My stomach was made bitter—My stomach was filled with bitterness.

[Rev 10:10](#)

*And he said to me: You must prophesy again about peoples and nations and kings—*This signifies the preaching of the Gospel, which was done in Asia. He composed first the Apocalypse on the isle of Patmos, into which he was expelled by Domitian,⁸⁷ and when it was reversed, the Gospel in Asia.⁸⁸ Because of this it is said: *You must prophesy again about peoples*, because by all peoples the prophecy was to be heard, which is in the Gospel.

[Rev 10:11](#)

*And I was given a rod like a staff—*Ezekiel shows this again, as he has announced spiritually the measurements of the heavenly city.⁸⁹

[Rev 11:1](#)

*Arise, measure the Lord's temple, and the altar, and those who worship in it—*he calls the temple the body of Christ. However, the Hebrews, when they did not understand the prophecy, tried to build it in the days of Zerubbabel and Sharbashar, leader of Cyrus's army, according to the measures that Ezekiel stated. And they were impeded, because they were unable. He therefore calls the temple, and at the same time the church, his body, in which, as he dwells in it, he resides in us. He thus again says: *Destroy this temple.*⁹⁰ But, because they wanted to adduce earthly glory and measure, again from this they were impeded. Some things are what the prophet signified, and others, what the Hebrews wanted to do. *And those who worship in it—*In what temple do the saints worship, if not in that which is Christ?

*And the court that is within the temple, send outside, and do not measure it—*He has adduced this, because many who are thought to be within, because they have believed, will then be driven away, when they are to be reckoned with the sinful nations, because they have not carried themselves according to the measure of grace, according to that: *He will send his angels and gather from his kingdom the stumbling blocks and cast them into the furnace of fire, and the righteous will shine like the sun.*⁹¹

[Rev 11:2](#)

*And the holy city shall they tread under foot forty-two months—*The city is the Church; and these months they are to persecute her and kill, when the false Christ⁹² shall come, because she does not worship him. Now, of this said Daniel, He

⁸⁶ Cf. Hippolytus, *Ben. Mos.* s.v. [Dan.](#)

⁸⁷ See note 13 above.

⁸⁸ Cf. Victorinus, *Comm. Apoc.* [10.3–11.1](#). Victorinus goes on to say (with obvious anachronism) that John wrote his Gospel “when Valentinus and Cerinthus and Ebion and other sects of Satan had spread throughout the world.” For this, especially the telltale fictitious eponym *Ebion*, cf. Hippolytus, *Haer.* [7.34](#), undoubtedly echoing his own lost *Syntagma*. Now, the latter shares a source (Hegesippus?) with Irenaeus, who reports (*Haer.* [1.26.3](#), [3.11.1](#)) that Cerinthus's error was refuted (prospectively) in John's Gospel, just as the earlier Nicolaitans had been denounced in his Apocalypse; from this, Hippolytus may well have inferred that the Apocalypse preceded the Gospel, a point then suggesting a meaning for *prophesy again*. Epiphanius, *Haer.* [51.12.2](#), [51.33.9](#), likewise places the writing of the Gospel after John's return from exile on Patmos (under Claudius!).

⁸⁹ [Ezek 42:15](#).

⁹⁰ [John 2:19](#).

⁹¹ [Matt 13:41–43](#). From here to the end of Rev 11, the translation is adapted from Gwynn, “Hippolytus on St. Matthew xxiv. 15–22,” 137–40.

⁹² [Matt 24:24](#).

shall approve the covenant for many, one week; in the half week shall cease the sacrifice.⁹³ The half week: that is, three and a half years; and these make the forty-two months that are mentioned. The sacrifice he speaks of is not that of sheep, but the prayers of the upright. And the holy city he speaks of is the righteous, i.e., those who are oppressed and trodden under foot by the horn that sprang up in the midst, which is the Antichrist, as Daniel said.⁹⁴

Hippolytus⁹⁵ otherwise interprets what is said in the Gospel, When indeed you shall see the pollution of desolation:⁹⁶ for he says that it is not concerning the Jews, and the laying waste of Jerusalem, that these things are said, but concerning the end of the Antichrist. The elect⁹⁷ he speaks of are the Christians who are in this conflict. And he says, Pray that you fly not on the Sabbath or in winter:⁹⁸ i.e., he advises that we be not overtaken by those things that are coming on us, when we are unoccupied in righteousness, as the Jews on the Sabbath, or troubled with worldly cares and sins, as one that is in a winter storm.⁹⁹

There shall be tribulation such as there was not like it since the beginning of the world, etc.¹⁰⁰—Hippolytus says: In the siege of Vespasian this did not come to pass; for nothing new happened to the world in his days beyond the things that were before. If you speak of war, many times it has happened in former times: and if again of captives, there have not lacked massacres or blood-shedding that was more than that. And if of the eating of children and unclean beasts, lo also in the days of Ahab these things were.¹⁰¹ Accordingly it is not concerning Jerusalem that the Lord said this; for when He willed to speak concerning her, He said, When you shall see the army encompassing the city, know that the desolation thereof is nigh.¹⁰² Hence the pollution of devastations he speaks of is the Antichrist. And Daniel said: In the half of the week stands the abomination in the sanctuary.¹⁰³ Now, Vespasian did not set up in the temple an idol, but that legion which Trajanus Quintus placed, a chief man of the Romans: he set up the idol there that is called Kore.¹⁰⁴ Also the Apostle has written that these things are concerning the Antichrist: Except if there come first a falling away, and the Man of iniquity be revealed, so that he as God shall

⁹³ Dan 9:27.

⁹⁴ Cf. Dan 7:8, 20–21, 25, 8:10. Cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 25.2–3; *Comm. Dan.* 4.12.4–5.

⁹⁵ In the margin is added, “in the interpretation of the Gospel.” Gwynn, “Hippolytus on St. Matthew xxiv. 15–22,” 142, suggests that this refers to a lost commentary on Matthew by Hippolytus, to which Jerome, *Comm. Matt.* praef. 4, may also refer, and of which Achelis, *Hippolytus Werke*, 2:195–208 ([link](#)), collects putative fragments. But, on the contrary, see Camplani and Prinzivalli, “Nuovi frammenti siriaci,” 71n58.

⁹⁶ Matt 24:15.

⁹⁷ Matt 24:22, 24.

⁹⁸ Matt 24:20.

⁹⁹ Cf. Hippolytus, *Comm. Dan.* 4.52.1.

¹⁰⁰ Matt 24:21; cf. Dan 12:1.

¹⁰¹ 2 Kgs 6:28.

¹⁰² Luke 21:20.

¹⁰³ Dan 9:27; cf. 11:31.

¹⁰⁴ Kore is better known as Persephone, and “Trajanus Quintus” must be an error for Trajan’s general Quietus. However, the parallel Hippolytan fragment in Achelis, *Hippolytus Werke*, 2:197–98 ([link](#)), refers simply to Caesar’s image. See Tibor Grüll, “Kore on the Temple Mount?,” *Specimina Nova* 18 (2004): 227–36 ([link](#)).

*sit in the temple, whom our Lord Jesus shall consume, etc.*¹⁰⁵ From these words it is evident that Vespasian did not call himself God, nor did he *sit in the temple*, nor was he killed *by the Spirit of the Lord*. Accordingly, it is manifest that in the end tribulation arises against the Church, *such as was none like it*.

And I will give my two witnesses, and they will prophesy, etc.—There come two prophets, Enoch and Elijah, and these are the two olive trees he speaks of, even as Zechariah spoke of them.¹⁰⁶ Now, concerning Elijah our Lord said: *Elijah must come to restore all things.*¹⁰⁷ Of these he says that they work miracles and signs and send plagues upon the unbelieving, in order that the faithful may have some respite. These two prophets will stand up against Antichrist, even as Moses and Aaron stood up against Pharaoh and the Egyptians. These things then are to be in the half week, when the Antichrist will scatter all men, so that there shall not be found two or three together to assemble, to offer sacrifice to God. This then is to be fulfilled: *The sacrifice shall cease.*¹⁰⁸ When then these are killed there by the false Christ, afterwards they are to stand up, in presence of many, and are to be caught upon the clouds to meet our Lord.¹⁰⁹ In the half week—John said: Enoch and Elijah are to receive power and preach a thousand two hundred and sixty days girt with sackcloth and to teach repentance to the people and the Gentiles. These days are the half week; and these are the two olive trees and the two candlesticks, as Zechariah said,¹¹⁰ Enoch and Elijah.¹¹¹

Rev 11:3–6

And the beast that ascends out of the bottomless pit shall make war against them, and shall overcome them, and kill them. And their dead bodies he shall cast into the streets (that is, the highways) of the city—Concerning this beast Daniel said: *I saw indeed a beast that came up out of the bottomless pit, that is, the sea and made war with the saints, which (beast) that horn which sprang up designates.*¹¹² No other kingdom is to persecute the saints, save this alone from which the horn is to spring up at the last, which is the Antichrist,¹¹³ who is to kill Enoch and Elijah. And after these things will come to pass what Isaiah said: *Behold the Lord out of His sanctuary sends forth his sword, great and strong, against the dragon, the crooked serpent;*¹¹⁴ and in like manner said Daniel: *The beast was killed and destroyed, and his body was given to the burning fire.*¹¹⁵ The body he speaks of is the devil, he who works in the false Christ, and the city he speaks of is Jerusalem, where these things are to come to pass; for Paul said concerning him who is the Antichrist: *He sits in the temple of God as God.*¹¹⁶

Rev 11:7–8

¹⁰⁵ 2 Thess 2:3, 4, 8.

¹⁰⁶ Zech 4:3, 11, 14.

¹⁰⁷ Matt 17:11; Mark 9:12.

¹⁰⁸ Dan 9:27.

¹⁰⁹ Rev 11:11–12; 1 Thess 4:17.

¹¹⁰ Zech 4:3.

¹¹¹ Cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 43.2; *Comm. Dan.* 4.35.3.

¹¹² Dan 7:3, 8, 21.

¹¹³ Cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 25.2–3.

¹¹⁴ Isa 26:21, 27:1.

¹¹⁵ Dan 7:11.

¹¹⁶ 2 Thess 2:7, 9. Gwynn's translation ends here.

*A woman clothed with the sun, and the moon under her feet, and upon her head a crown of twelve stars. And when she was pregnant, she shouted and in labor was struggling to give birth—That here indicates the persecutions and vexations that the church must suffer by the Antichrist. For he calls the church the woman; clothed with the sun, because she is clothed with the paternal word that shines more than the sun. And the moon under her feet—adorned with heavenly beauty like the moon. And upon her head a crown of twelve stars—the twelve apostles, whose is the Church's firmness. And she shouted and was struggling to give birth—because continually and incessantly she gives birth from her heart to the Word, and indeed in the world she suffers persecution by the unbelieving.*¹¹⁷

Rev 12:1–2

*And behold, a red dragon, having seven heads and ten horns, and upon his head seven diadems. And his tail draws a third of the stars of the sky, etc.—What Daniel also names a beast, John calls a dragon, i.e., the Antichrist, or the Slanderer, the dragon, who urges him to persecute the saints. He calls the saints stars, according to what our Lord said: *The righteous will shine like the stars*.¹¹⁸ When there are saints in that temple in the great tribulation, he will seize and abduct certain ones of them into his wickedness, and he will overthrow the traces of the elect.*

Rev 12:3–4

*And she gave birth to a male child, who is to shepherd all the nations—He called Christ male, who is God and himself man, whom the Church procures immediately and teaches to all the nations. And her son was carried off to God and to his throne—because he is the heavenly king and the Son of the Father, as David says: *The Lord said to my Lord, sit at my right hand*.¹¹⁹*

Rev 12:5

And that woman fled into the desert, where a place was prepared for her by God; she there finished a thousand two hundred sixty days. And battle was waged in heaven—The woman is the church who suffers persecution by the Antichrist. And the faithful who call upon the Church in the presence of the pseudo-Christ will flee or scatter: and they will depart into places that now lack religion, that their gospel may be announced in the whole earth.¹²⁰ And a thousand two hundred sixty days are three and a half years or half a week: the faithful will be in straits in these days, and sacrifice will cease.¹²¹ Battle in heaven is a tumult of the heavens, and virtues are the angels. For when the Lord comes, he will send the angels who will gather the elect.¹²² For when these things happen, the disturbance in heaven will not be meager,¹²³ but all will be in terror just like men struck down with trembling of war.¹²⁴

Rev 12:6–7

He pursued the woman who had given birth to the male; and she was given two wings of that great eagle, to fly into the desert: to be nourished there a time and times and half a time, away from the serpent's face—The time etc. are those

Rev 12:13–14

¹¹⁷ For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 60.1–61.1.

¹¹⁸ Matt 13:43; cf. Dan 12:3.

¹¹⁹ Ps 109(110):1. For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 61.1–2.

¹²⁰ Rom 10:18.

¹²¹ Dan 9:27.

¹²² Matt 24:31.

¹²³ Cf. Matt 24:29.

¹²⁴ For all this, cf. the Brock fragments, where this is a response to Gaius.

thousand two hundred and sixty days or half week, when the pseudo-Christ will seize and persecute the Church, who will flee from place to place¹²⁵ and hide herself in the mountains and in the desert. *And she has with her two wings*—the faithful in Christ, who, when he spreads his hands on the wood, spreads two wings—his right and left hand; and he will call the faithful and *he will gather them as a hen her chicks*.¹²⁶ And through Malachi he said: *To you fearing my name, that the face, the sun of justice, appear: and healing in its wings*.¹²⁷

And I saw another beast ascending from the earth, and it had two horns, like those of a lamb; and he spoke like a dragon—The beast that ascends from the earth declares the future kingdom of the Antichrist; the two horns, however: himself and the false prophet who is with him. That *his horns were like those of a lamb*—He wants to become like the Son of God and to set himself forward as king. That *he spoke like a dragon*, because he is a seducer and not truthful.¹²⁸

Rev 13:11

And all power preceded him to that first beast, and he made the earth and those who lived in it worship the first beast, whose mortal wound was healed—That signifies: after the image of the law of Augustus, by whom the Roman Empire was established, thus he also established and imposed the law of all, since he was strong, and through that obtained for himself great praise. However, this was the *fourth beast*, whose head was wounded and *healed* again, for he was destroyed and made an affront, *and he wore ten diadems*, because when he was eager for malice he was like him who cared for and renewed him.¹²⁹

Rev 13:12

This is what is said by the prophet: *He will give breath to the image, and the image of the beast will speak*—He will make those who are designated by him strengthened through the law. *And he will make all who do not worship the beast be killed*: then the *faith and patience of the saints* will appear.¹³⁰

Rev 13:15

He will give breath to the image of the beast—the *image of the beast* shows a figure of this present kingdom and what the Antichrist is to do then. For all that the present kingdom does by the operation of Satan against the saints, likewise then, when the Antichrist comes, he will establish and confirm that they are against the righteous. Of what must thus be fulfilled, the Apocalypse justly says: *He will give breath to the image of the beast, and the image will speak*—He will strengthen those who are established by the image of the kingdom as if by the name, and he will do thus.¹³¹

And he will make all these, small and great and rich, etc., and he will give them a sign upon their hands—For he is shrewd and eager to be exalted over the servants of God. And he wants to harass and drive them out of the world, because they do not give him praise. *That a sign be given to them*—by this the Antichrist wants to imitate the Lord, and he gives the seal of his name to those who are gathered in his

Rev 13:16

¹²⁵ Matt 23:34.

¹²⁶ Matt 23:37.

¹²⁷ Mal 4:2. For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 61.2–3.

¹²⁸ For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 49.1.

¹²⁹ For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 49.2.

¹³⁰ Cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 49.3.

¹³¹ Cf. the Brock fragments, where Gaius objects to Rev 13:15–18 and cites Matt 23:34.

house, so that even in this he oppressed the saints, and he will order everyone everywhere to build up a sanctuary, so that none of the saints can buy, *but such a one who has the sign*,¹³² which is given upon the right hand. However, that says [to be imposed] *upon the seat of the eyes*, or the forehead: because they will crown with a foreign crown, not of life but of death, all whom they deceive with themselves. Thus did Antiochus Epiphanes, the Antiochene, from the family of Alexander; for when he boasted in his heart, he ordered altars to be built; and indeed that all celebrate the feast of Dionysius crowned in wood: but they killed those who did not sacrifice. *And the Lord struck him with worms, and he died*, as it is written in Maccabees.¹³³

And his number is: six hundred sixty-six—it is not permitted to be equally definite about his name: for we see that many names arrive at this reckoning, for example *Titin* or *Auntos*, and others such.¹³⁴ This computation occurs in the alphabet of the Greeks, and not in the alphabet of the Syrians. *Taw* in the Greek language is three hundred, and in ours *teth* is nine. But because, as we said before: *The beast's wound was healed, and he made the image speak*—that he be strengthened, the manifestation is of those who now dominate, i.e., of the Romans.¹³⁵ The Romans, before they had this name, were called *Latins*, and one of them is called a *Latin*. However, from this name the number of one man is collected. *Latin* is the name ΛΕΑΤΙΝΟΣ (*Leatinos*).¹³⁶ According to the numeration of the Greeks, those signs are applied: as we said, *taw* is three hundred among the Greeks, seventy [...] such is the name of the beast and the number of his name.

That is mixed undiluted—that is mixed without mixture, namely, a drink with which nothing is mixed or conjoined.

And he harvested the vine of the earth and threw it into the press of the wrath of God. And that press was trampled outside the city, and blood flowed out from the press up to the bridles of horses, for a thousand six hundred stades—Zechariah has also spoken thus of the war, which before the coming of the Lord will be started by that adversary against those who in the beginning stood against him.¹³⁷ This demonstration, however, is a type of the great breaking off of peoples and kingdoms, as also Ezekiel says that whoever opposes him in battle will fall into ruin.¹³⁸ And Zechariah says: Before the harvest, when it is finished, there will be a flower, and there will be bitter grapes, and he will sever those little clusters with sickles, and he will sever and tear off the branches, and he will leave them to the

¹³² Text corrupt and obscure, according to the editor.

¹³³ 2 Mac 9:9. For all this, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 49.4–5.

¹³⁴ Cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 50.1–2 (apparently following Irenaeus, *Haer.* 5.30.3), where the names proposed are *Titan* (Τειτάν) and *Evanthas* (Εὐάνθας).

¹³⁵ In this age *Romans* would mean Byzantines, in continuity with the Roman Empire of Hippolytus's age.

¹³⁶ Again, cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 50.3 (and Irenaeus, *Haer.* 5.30.3), where the name is *Latinus* (Λατεῖνος). In this case the Greek letters are written out.

¹³⁷ Cf. Zech 14.

¹³⁸ Cf. Ezek 6:12.

flying things of the sky and the animals of the earth.¹³⁹ And John says things similar to these that will be before the coming of the Lord.

Golden belts on their chest—bound on their chests with a golden bond. [Rev 15:6–7](#)

Bowls are jugs or dishes.

To the place that is called in Hebrew Megiddo, in Greek Armageddon—We see again what John says of Babylon, which thrust him into exile.¹⁴⁰ [Rev 16:16](#)

Come, I will show you the judgment of the harlot who sits upon many waters, etc., up to the blood of the prophets and the saints and all the slain upon the earth—In all the things that are said above, he indicates the torture and particular harms that will come upon Babylon in the end, on the part of the tyrants who will be then. [Rev 17–18](#)

*And he laid hold on the dragon, the old serpent, which is the Devil, and Satan, and bound him a thousand years, and cast him into the bottomless pit, and shut him up and sealed the bottomless pit upon him, in order that he should not deceive the nations until the thousand years should be fulfilled: after that, he must be loosed a little season*¹⁴¹—Gaius the heretic objects: that Satan is bound here, according to what is written: *Christ went up into the strong man's house and bound him, and spoiled his goods* for us.¹⁴² [Rev 20:2–3](#)

Hippolytus answers him and says: If the Devil has been bound, how does he deceive the faithful and persecute and plunder men? And if you say that he has been bound as regards the faithful, how did he draw near against Christ, him who did no sin? According to the text: *The prince comes and finds no sin in me.*¹⁴³ And if then he has been bound, how did the Lord teach us to pray, that we should *be delivered from the evil one*?¹⁴⁴ And why did he desire to tempt Simon and the apostles, and how was one who had been bound able to sift and trouble the disciples?¹⁴⁵ And truly for us *the conflict is not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, and against the rulers of the darkness of this world.*¹⁴⁶ If he had been bound, he would not maintain the conflict, or catch away the word which was sown, as is said in the Parable of the Seed.¹⁴⁷ That he *has bound the strong man*; the meaning of it is this: that he has rebuked and cast scorn on those who did not come unto him when he went against the Devil in order to purify them from his bondage and make them sons unto the Father. And this is proved by what he said just after: *he that is not with me is against me, and he that does not gather with me scatters abroad.*¹⁴⁸ Accordingly, in the end of times, *the Devil is to be bound and to be flung into the bottomless pit*, when the Lord comes; even as Isaiah has said: *the wicked shall be*

¹³⁹ Cf. [Isa 18:5–6](#) (not Zechariah).

¹⁴⁰ Cf. Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 36.1.

¹⁴¹ This section's translation is adapted from Gwynn, "Hippolytus and His 'Heads against Caius,'" 402–4.

¹⁴² [Matt 12:29](#).

¹⁴³ Cf. [John 14:30](#).

¹⁴⁴ [Matt 6:13](#).

¹⁴⁵ [Luke 22:31](#).

¹⁴⁶ [Eph 6:12](#).

¹⁴⁷ [Matt 13:19](#).

¹⁴⁸ [Matt 12:30](#).

taken away in order that he see not the glory of the Lord.¹⁴⁹ And the number of the years is not the number of days, but it represents the space of one day, glorious and perfect; in which, when the king comes in glory with his slain, the creation is to shine, according to the text: *The sun will shine sevenfold*;¹⁵⁰ while the righteous eat with him and drink of his vine. *This is the day that the Lord has made*, of which David spoke.¹⁵¹ Accordingly, when with the eye of the spirit John saw the glory of that day, he likened it to the space of a thousand years; according to the saying: *One day in the world of the righteous is as a thousand years*.¹⁵² And by the number he shows that day to be perfect, for those that are faithful. But as for what he has said: *after the thousand years he shall be loosed and shall deceive the nations*, it is this: that justly he is to be loosed, and to be cast into the burning, and to be judged; with those who from old time were gathered together with him, when he gathered the strangers of the kingdom, and Gog and Magog.¹⁵³

I saw thrones that had been placed, and they sat upon them, and judgment over their souls, etc.—The saints do not receive a single reward, as if established in equality. Greater will be the reward of the virgin than that of the married; also that of him who has suffered martyrdom for our Lord, greater than that of him who has not rendered testimony. For what is said, he will give a denarius to the first and to those who have come toward evening,¹⁵⁴ means about life, because all live; he calls life a denarius. Because the righteous will rise first, Zechariah teaches: *The Lord will come and all the saints with him*;¹⁵⁵ Isaiah: *The dead will rise, and those in tombs will be revived*;¹⁵⁶ and Paul: *The dead who in Christ will rise first*.¹⁵⁷ And thus on the matter says John, that the slain are raised first on that glorious day. He calls this the *first resurrection*, not because there is a second resurrection, but he teaches of the order of the righteous, who are to be the first to enter into the kingdom; the second order is of those who will be rejected like the goats.¹⁵⁸ Some say that all the dead are resurrected together in the blink of an eye; but the righteous first and afterwards the wicked.

St. Severus said, what is written in the Apocalypse: *Blessed and holy who takes part in that first resurrection*—It is not a first and second resurrection according to time; for there is one resurrection, and God has assigned one day for judgment,¹⁵⁹ but he calls the resurrection the first, because the orders prior and more excellent pertain to it, according to that: *Many are the mansions of my father's*

Rev 20:4–5

Rev 20:6

¹⁴⁹ Isa 26:10 (LXX). Likewise cited in Hippolytus, *Antichr.* 63.2.

¹⁵⁰ Isa 30:26.

¹⁵¹ Ps 117(118):24.

¹⁵² 2 Pet 3:8.

¹⁵³ Rev 20:7–10. Gwynn's translation ends here.

¹⁵⁴ Cf. Matt 20:10.

¹⁵⁵ Zech 14:5.

¹⁵⁶ Isa 26:19.

¹⁵⁷ 1 Thess 4:16.

¹⁵⁸ Cf. Matt 25:32–33.

¹⁵⁹ Acts 17:31.

house;¹⁶⁰ for if there are many mansions, also equally many orders, thus that this be first, another second, that third; and the first order is of those who were bound.¹⁶¹

And I saw a great white throne, and him who sits upon it: and from his face fled the earth and the heaven—After the day of revelation that the faithful and unfaithful see, he will say to those who are left and have not yet tasted death: Come with me, that you enter your chambers and hide until the wrath has passed. Because, however, *the heavens and the earth fled, and a place was not found for them*, he shows the stupor of all creation and the commotion of the elements, because of the wrath that occurs. Through that: *a place was not found for them*, he shows that they did not perish, but in a stupor were shaken in a tremor, when he arose in the divine wrath who created everything; who afterwards will restore everything that will be renewed, according to that: *There will be a new heaven and a new earth*;¹⁶² and the Apostle: *The expectation of creation for the revelation of the sons of God*,¹⁶³ because this creation will also be freed from the servitude of corruption.

Rev 20:11

Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the lamb. And he took me in spirit upon a great mountain, and he showed me the holy city Jerusalem, and below: and that city was placed as a square—by four corners it is established.

Rev 21:9–16

And the structure of its wall—the construction of its wall. *Jasper or jasipon; sapphire or sapphila; agate or chalcedony; emerald; the fifth, onyx or red; the sixth, carnelian or sardonyx; the seventh, chrysolite or golden stone; the eighth, beryl; the ninth, topaz or pazon; the tenth, chrysoprase or purple gold; the eleventh, jacinth, i.e., hyacinth; the twelfth, amethyst or reddening*—These are said of the church, which is built with these precious stones, i.e., the saints, who just like the stones are assembled by the Word as the worker and are built as a city, and on that day they will be filled with glory and God will dwell in it. The twelve stones signify mystically the twelve tribes, who were scattered through righteousness and through which the nations accessed God. And the twelve foundations are the twelve names of the apostles; they themselves are the foundations of the Church, which they bear.¹⁶⁴ And he said their walls from very precious stones, i.e., the righteous and the virgins and the saints; who are sturdy, by whom the wall of the city is built, they themselves are the keepers of those who dwell in their midst. And these mysteries, which spiritually are fulfilled today, are those of which Moses had ordered types to be done. He served spiritual things with spiritual things, which now mystically the Father works, that they be shown complete and perfect.

Rev 21:18–20

And he showed me the river of the water of life. A river as of crystal, flowing from the seat of God and the lamb in the middle of the street—That river of life is baptism. *In the middle of the city*—in the midst of the church.

Rev 22:1

¹⁶⁰ John 14:2.

¹⁶¹ Cf. Severus of Antioch, *Ep.* 72. Bar Šalibi may know it, as we do, through John of Dara.

¹⁶² Rev 21:1.

¹⁶³ Rom 8:19.

¹⁶⁴ Cf. the Brock fragments, where Hippolytus says this.

And the tree of life that bore fruit—The tree of life, of which he says, *from here and there on the bank of the river*, shows the passion of Christ, in which, when man first believes, he descends into the waters and washes away his sins. [Rev 22:2](#)

Twelve in every month—For those twelve fruits are the twelve apostles, whose words are like leaves to the health of the people.

And the leaves of the tree the health of the people—What are now in the Church and counted little will then be revealed in glory. The health and knowledge that we will receive there is much more sublime than what is ministered here.

Revised 7 Nov 2021